Begin the Conversation About Your Wife's Future Care Without Pushing a Decision

Four prompts to find a gentle way in, write down what she wants to keep, be honest about what each of you can offer, and leave with a starting point the family can return to.

Where you are

Your wife is well and independent, and the subject of future care has never come up. You'd like to know what she would want preserved if things change, and you don't want the first conversation to sound like a plan to move her anywhere.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You've had a first conversation that stayed about her life, not about a move. You know what she wants to keep, and the family has said honestly what each person could offer.

A one-page starting point with four headings: What She Wants to Keep, How We Raised It and What She Said, What Each of Us Can Honestly Offer, and Questions for Later.

Before you start

- A few lines about how your wife tends to react when the future comes up.
- Notes from the conversation once you've had it, in her words where you can.
- A short, honest note from each of the kids about what they could offer. You can begin with the first item alone.

PROMPT 1

Find a gentle way in

WHY THIS MATTERS

The hardest part is the first sentence. If it sounds like a plan, she'll hear a verdict. If it starts with permission and with ordinary life, it's just a conversation between two people who've had thousands.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A few lines about your wife: how she feels about planning, what she enjoys about her days, and anything that makes this subject touchy.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I want to talk with my wife about what she would want if she ever needed more help, but nothing is wrong right now and I don't want it to sound like I'm planning something behind her back.

> Here is a little about her and how she tends to react to this kind of subject:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Give me three short ways to ask her permission to have the conversation, each in a different tone. Then give me six questions about everyday life I could ask once she agrees, about good days, routines, and what she'd hate to lose. Don't include anything about moving, facilities, or her health. Don't suggest what she might answer.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

An opening you can imagine saying over coffee, not across a desk.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask permission first, and accept it if the answer is 'not today.'

PROMPT 2

Write down what she wants to keep

WHY THIS MATTERS

Once she's talked, the risk is that you remember what you expected to hear. Writing her words down soon after, and separating them from your own conclusions, protects what she actually said.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes from the conversation, as close to her words as you can get them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I had a first conversation with my wife about what matters to her as she gets older. Here is what she said, as near to her words as I could write it afterward:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Sort it into four lists: ROUTINES AND THINGS SHE WANTS TO KEEP; HER OWN WORDS, quoted exactly where I quoted her; THINGS SHE WASN'T SURE ABOUT OR DIDN'T WANT TO DISCUSS; and THINGS I CONCLUDED THAT SHE DIDN'T ACTUALLY SAY. Keep the fourth list honest. Then suggest two or three gentle follow-up questions for another day, based only on what she left open.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The fourth list. It shows how much of the picture is still yours rather than hers.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the first two lists back to her sometime and ask if that's right.

PROMPT 3

Be honest about what each of you can offer

WHY THIS MATTERS

In a calm moment, it's easy to say 'we'll take care of you.' Later, a son with a job two states away can't, and the promise becomes a wound. Asking what each person could really do, and what would change it, is kinder than any promise.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A few honest lines from each family member about what they could do, how often, and what they couldn't.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I asked our children and the family members who would be involved what they could realistically offer if my wife needed more help, how often, and what they couldn't do. Here are their answers:
>
> [PASTE EACH PERSON'S ANSWER, LABELED]
>
> Make a table: WHO, WHAT THEY COULD DO, HOW OFTEN, WHAT THEY COULDN'T DO, and WHAT IT DEPENDS ON, such as a job, distance, their own health, or a partner's agreement. Then write two lists: things more than one person offered, and things nobody offered. Don't judge anyone's answer, and don't add up whether it would be enough.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The 'what it depends on' column. That's where promises quietly live.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Thank each person for being honest, especially the ones who said less than you hoped.

PROMPT 4

Make the page you'll come back to

WHY THIS MATTERS

This isn't a plan. It's a starting point, written while there is time, that the family can read again in a year and change. The last job is to put it on one page and keep the unanswered questions visible instead of letting them disappear.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What came back from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my family and I have gathered from our first conversations about my wife's future care:
>
> [PASTE WHAT CAME BACK FROM THE FIRST THREE PROMPTS]
>
> Write a one-page starting point with four headings: WHAT SHE WANTS TO KEEP, in her words where I have them; HOW WE RAISED IT AND WHAT SHE SAID; WHAT EACH OF US CAN HONESTLY OFFER, including what it depends on; and QUESTIONS FOR LATER, drawn from what she left open and what nobody has offered. Keep the tone warm and plain. Do not propose any arrangement, service, or move, and don't score whether the family's offers are enough. End with the line “We'll look at this again when...” for us to finish together.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page she could read herself and feel she was heard.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show it to her first. Then keep it somewhere the family can find, and take it to the next step below.

A gentle next step, when you're both ready.

What you've written captures her wishes and the family's honest limits. The care interview adds the rest of her situation, area by area, into a Family Care Profile, so the family has one place to keep what she wants as the years go on.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›